

Ethnic Barriers to Civil Resistance

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Abstract

While ethnic cleavages have featured prominently in our understanding of civil wars, attention to ethnic and social structures has been surprisingly absent from the recent wave of research on civil resistance. Yet these structures likely have an important impact on when and where we see nonviolent campaigns occur. This article argues that the strategic logic of civil resistance presents high barriers to entry for politically excluded ethnic minorities. Constraints on these groups' ability to activate mechanisms central to an exclusively nonviolent strategy either prevent them from getting a civil resistance campaign off the ground or deter them from ever attempting to do so. Using original data on the ethnic composition of nonviolent and violent campaigns, I show that nonviolent campaigns are less likely than violent ones to include participants from politically disadvantaged ethnic groups and also less likely to feature ethnic political claims. Furthermore, I find that political exclusion and small group size reduce the likelihood that members of an ethnic group will initiate a campaign of civil resistance.

Keywords: nonviolence, civil resistance, ethnic conflict, civil war

Introduction

When they occur, civil wars play out along ethnic lines with astounding frequency. According to a recent study by [Denny and Walter \(2014\)](#), 64 percent of civil wars between 1946 and 2005 in the PRIO Battle Deaths Dataset Version 3.0 ([Lacina and Gleditsch, 2005](#)) were initiated by groups expressing political grievances on behalf of their self-identified ethnic group. [Buhaug \(2006\)](#) similarly finds that ethnic conflicts make up a majority of cases in four major civil war datasets. Do civil resistance campaigns follow a similar pattern?

Despite a few iconic cases of racially or ethnically motivated campaigns of nonviolent resistance, such as the anti-Apartheid struggle in South Africa, the civil resistance literature has paid comparatively little attention to the role of ethnicity in shaping this form of conflict. Instead, research on nonviolent conflict has focused primarily on identifying factors related to movement agency—strategic planning ([Ackerman and Kruegler 1994](#)), the use of diverse tactics ([Schock 2005](#)), and the maintenance of nonviolent discipline ([Sharp 1973](#))—that these schol-

ars argue matter most when it comes to explaining the trajectories and outcomes of such campaigns. Some studies that seek to identify predictors of the onset nonviolent campaigns include measures of ethnicity in their list of covariates but generally focus more on measures of economic and political structure, with less theoretical attention to the role that social structure might play ([Butcher and Svensson 2016](#); [Chenoweth and Ulfelder 2017](#)).

[Svensson and Lindgren \(2011\)](#) are an important exception: they show that the success rate for nonviolence in nondemocracies is lower when opponents and the regime are divided along ethnic lines. Still, this does not address how ethnic cleavages might inform when and where campaigns employing civil resistance materialize in the first place.

In this study, I argue that an ethnic group's level of political inclusion and demographic size impact the likelihood that its members will initiate a civil resistance campaign. Following the strategic logic of nonviolent action elaborated in the civil resistance literature (see, e.g., [Chenoweth and Stephan 2011](#)), I expect that small

and excluded ethnic groups face high hurdles when considering nonviolent resistance. Specifically, the size of the ethnic group places a ceiling on its ability to generate mass popular mobilization, and a lack of social ties to members of the ruling regime likely makes inducing loyalty shifts from elites particularly challenging. Additionally, ethnic cleavages between the opposition and ruling elites may make it easier for the state to call upon its security forces to exact brutal repression on nonviolent activists.

As a result, movements whose supporters come from smaller, politically excluded ethnic groups will be more pessimistic about the potential viability of a nonviolent strategy, relative to movements whose supporters come from high-status, majority groups. They will therefore be less likely to choose to even attempt a campaign using a strategy of civil resistance, or if they do, will be less likely to get such a campaign off the ground.

Using new data that links campaigns in the NAVCO 2.0 dataset (Chenoweth and Lewis 2013) to politically relevant ethnic groups in the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) dataset (Vogt et al. 2015), I show that politically excluded ethnic groups initiate only 21 percent of nonviolent conflicts globally. Conversely, these groups initiate 52 percent of violent conflicts. Furthermore, while 57 percent of violent campaigns feature an ethnic political claim, only 20 percent of nonviolent ones do so. Using politically relevant ethnic groups as the level of analysis, I find that politically excluded groups are less than one-third as likely to initiate a nonviolent campaign compared to high-status groups. In addition, group size is strongly correlated with the likelihood of nonviolent campaign initiation.

The findings challenge the conventional wisdom among civil resistance scholars and advocates asserting that structural conditions matter little for civil resistance movements. In fact, social structures, as opposed to the more frequently examined economic and institutional structures, play a major role in conditioning the emergence of nonviolent campaigns. By demonstrating how group characteristics raise and lower barriers to the adoption of exclusively nonviolent repertoires of contention, the study also highlights the importance of disaggregating actors to better understand the dynamics of nonviolent resistance.

The rest of the article proceeds as follows. After first briefly reviewing scholarship on the role of ethnicity in violent and nonviolent conflict, I then present a theory for how ethnic structures and practices of political exclusion shape opportunities for civil resistance. Next, I introduce the Ethnic Groups in Contention (EGC) dataset and compare the ethnic composition of violent

and nonviolent campaigns. I then present a series of multinomial logistical regressions with the group-year as the unit of analysis and examine the impact of power and demographic structures on the probability of ethnic groups initiating nonviolent and violent campaigns. I conclude with a discussion of the findings as well as implications for research, policy, and advocacy.

Ethnicity and Civil Resistance

Over the last three decades, scholarship on ethnic conflict and civil war has frequently intersected (see, e.g., Horowitz 1985; Posen 1993; Harff and Gurr 1994). Some scholars have, of course, challenged whether ethnic grievances truly drive large-scale armed conflicts (Mueller 2000; Fearon and Laitin 2003), while others have questioned the concept of ethnicity altogether, observing that rather than being fixed, rigid, and primordial, ethnic identities are fluid, fragmented, multidimensional, and often partly shaped by political institutions and processes (Kasfir 1979; Waters 1990; Laitin 1998; Posner 2005). But even if we allow for the fact that the salience of ethnic identity is highly contingent and that diverse ethnic groups cooperate far more often than they fight (Fearon and Laitin 1996), civil wars are nevertheless fought along ethnic lines more often than along any other type of cleavage (Denny and Walter 2014).

Explanations for ethnic conflict fall into two broad camps. The first stresses the relevance of ethnic group grievances as a motivating factor leading to high-risk collective action. These explanations largely emphasize patterns of discrimination and repression (Horowitz 1985; Gurr 1994), political exclusion (Wimmer, Cederman, and Min 2009; Cederman, Wimmer, and Min 2010), and inter-group economic inequalities (Cederman, Weidmann, and Gleditsch 2011) as triggers leading to the outbreak of ethnic conflict.

A second tradition highlights the ways in which ethnic social structures may be favorable for organizing rebellion. Ethnic ties may form a basis for incentivizing recruitment, maintaining trust, and enforcing discipline (Gates 2002; Humphreys and Weinstein 2006; Gubler and Selway 2012). Additionally, transnational kinship ties can be a key source of material support or safe hiding, and ultimately facilitate ethnic conflict (Cederman, Girardin, and Gleditsch 2009; Salehyan, Gleditsch, and Cunningham 2011).

Scholars of civil resistance have paid comparatively less attention to how ethnicity might influence the emergence of nonviolent strategies of resistance. Explanations of nonviolent campaign onset have focused instead on processes of modernization and globalization

(Butcher and Svensson 2016; Karakaya, forthcoming), political opportunity structures linked to electoral cycles or civil liberties (Chenoweth and Ulfelder 2017), and regional diffusion dynamics (Beissinger 2007; Gleditsch and Rivera 2017). While some of these studies include measures of ethnicity in their cross-national analyses, they rarely grant ethnicity variables explicit theoretical attention. Perhaps most importantly, a limitation to all of these studies is their focus on states as the unit of analysis, which overlooks the drastically different positions that different groups occupy within a given state. As a result, these studies cannot account for sub-national variation, such as we have seen in Indonesia, Myanmar, Nepal, or the Philippines, where we see members of different ethnic groups embrace different strategies—violent and nonviolent—within the same state.

Better understanding the role of ethnicity in nonviolent conflict requires turning away from the state as the unit of analysis to examine the unique characteristics of ethnic groups. Indeed, a similar turn took place in the civil war literature, away from what Chandra and Wilkinson (2008) call measures of “ethnic structure” and toward measures of “ethnic practice.” The turn yielded important findings. While state-level measures of ethnic diversity were only infrequently and inconsistently correlated to civil war onset, the Ethnic Power Relations project, by examining the political status of ethnic groups, demonstrated that ethnic groups excluded from executive-level state power were significantly more likely to launch insurgencies. This was especially true when excluded groups were larger and had recently experienced a downgrade in their political status (Cederman et al. 2010).

By examining the dynamics of nonviolent resistance at the level of groups, this article adopts a similar disaggregated analysis of the impact of ethnicity on nonviolent campaigns. In principle, civil resistance has the potential to provide aggrieved ethnic groups an alternative means through which to pursue their political goals. However, whereas the civil war literature argues that specific opportunity structures create conditions favorable to violent insurgency for excluded ethnic groups, these same structures raise barriers when it comes to the adoption of civil resistance strategies.

Ethnic Cleavages and the Strategic Logic of Nonviolent Action

While large-scale protests often appear to be chaotic and spontaneous, the literatures on civil resistance and social movements demonstrate that collective action is often the result of coordinated efforts by social movement

organizations (Morris 1984; Schock 2005; Cunningham, Dahl, and Frugé 2017). In fact, there is ample evidence that organization leaders engage in processes of strategic calculation, anticipating the likely consequences of alternative courses of action and ultimately choosing the strategy they deem most likely to offer success. Barrell (1992), for example, recounts the African National Congress’s “strategic review” of 1978 and 1979, in which it formally decided to transition from a primarily military strategy to one of political organizing. This set the foundation for the United Democratic Front’s nonviolent campaign in the 1980s. MacLeod (2015, 71) describes how the West Papuan self-determination movement conducted “a cost-benefit analysis of the relative effectiveness of different methods.” My own research has examined how Nepal’s Nepali Congress and Maoist parties each held secret meetings in which they deliberated the relative advantages of violent and nonviolent approaches (Thurber 2016).

If movements engage in a rational or quasi-rational decision-making process, what variables affect their assessments of the viability of a nonviolent strategy? Scholarship on civil resistance consistently emphasizes three key “comparative advantages” of nonviolent resistance campaigns that help them achieve higher rates of success, relative to violent resistance: (1) nonviolent movements create higher costs of repression; (2) they can win over defections from elites within the regime; and (3) they generate higher rates of participation. Movement leaders likely understand the importance of these mechanisms and are likely to ask themselves whether they can mobilize a large number of individuals for active participation; whether they can recruit powerful actors to their cause; and whether they will be repressed for mobilizing.

In the case of ethnic groups, the dynamics of ethnic politics are likely to influence how movements evaluate the answers to these questions, and consequently their likelihoods of attempting civil resistance campaigns.

One of the greatest obstacles nonviolent movements face is the prospect of brutal repression by the state (Goodwin 2001; Davenport 2015; Chenoweth, Perkosi, and Kang 2017). Indeed, by openly challenging a regime while foregoing weapons, nonviolent activists appear to leave themselves largely defenseless against state repression. However, ordering security forces to engage in the repression (especially lethal repression) of unarmed protesters is a very difficult task. Professional codes of conduct, fears of harming friends, family, or neighbors, and basic morality can make soldiers and police reluctant to use force. As Sharon Nepstad (2013, 344) describes in her account of military defectors in Syria: “...they are

faced with a moral dilemma: loyalty to the regime requires them to repress their own people. Repeatedly, in interviews, many defectors have stated that they simply could not do this.” They may opt instead to shirk orders or even abandon their posts. Even when security forces do engage in repression, such actions often “backfire” and create moral outrage against the regime that has used force on unarmed protesters (Martin 2007). The outcome is often greater popular support for the movement and defections away from the state by key regime elites.

Excluded ethnic groups, however, might be dubious of the backfire mechanism applying to them. Numerous psychological studies show that individuals are more willing to inflict physical harm on those they perceive as members of a different social group. For example, in numerous follow-ups to Milgram’s (1974) infamous shock experiments, scholars have consistently found that human subjects are more reticent to harm another individual when that individual is observably different in terms of race, linguistic dialect, or accent (Brant 1980). In the context of protests, Davenport, Armstrong, and Soule (2011) find that white police officers in the United States were more likely to make arrests during demonstrations in which a majority of participants were black relative to protests in which the participants were predominantly white. And Johnson (2017) finds that when security forces are more “socially distant” from protesters, they are more likely to use repressive force. In another example from my own research, prior experiences with police brutality caused leaders of Nepal’s Magar ethnic community to believe that attempts at civil resistance would be met with severe repression (Thurber 2016).

Politically excluded ethnic groups will also be more skeptical that they can activate another key mechanism of nonviolent success—elite defections. A lack of co-ethnics in state institutions makes winning over loyalty-shifts difficult. Elites within the regime may see the political agenda of another ethnic group as counter to their own interests and a threat to a favorable status quo. Furthermore, ethnic cleavages between movement members and regime elites reduce the likelihood of direct interpersonal relationships across sides, which civil resistance scholarship cites as key to convincing elites to commit to the risky act of defection (Binnendijk and Marovic 2009; Jaafar and Stephan 2010).

Finally, mass participation is the *sine qua non* of campaign effectiveness for nonviolent movements (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011). The logic behind this is straightforward: more people engaging in nonviolent anti-regime mobilization—from street protests to strikes to boycotts—increases the effectiveness of those tactics

by raising the costs imposed on the regime and heightening the threat to regime power. Simply put, the more people involved in carrying out acts of nonviolent resistance, the greater the disruption those tactics cause. In fact, as DeNardo (1985, 35) points out, “it is nearly impossible to imagine political circumstances where the disruptiveness of dissident activity would diminish as its scope increased.”

There may be some advantages to overcoming barriers to collective action within an ethnic group. Gubler and Selway (2012) theorize that common nationalist purpose, a greater ability to exert social pressure and control, and enhanced communication help ethnic-based movements mobilize in the context of violent insurgencies. While these factors may increase the rate of participation among members of the ethnic group, the overall size of the ethnic group likely places a ceiling on the overall mobilization potential of the movement. This is especially likely to be the case if the grievances around which people have mobilized are group specific. In short, though maximizing rates of participation in high-risk activity may be very important for armed rebels, the need for high absolute numbers is far greater for ethnic groups organizing civil resistance campaigns. Excluded ethnic groups, especially small ones, are likely to perceive the possibility of filling city squares with mass crowds as nearly impossible.

On the other hand, an excluded ethnic group that is sufficiently large may be more likely to achieve sufficient levels of mass mobilization. In fact, this may help explain some prominent cases of ethnic-based nonviolent resistance, such as the anti-Apartheid struggle in South Africa. These cases are nevertheless rare, as demographic size and political power often go hand in hand. Furthermore, cases such as the First Palestinian Intifada and the initial nonviolent resistance in Syria show that large excluded ethnic groups still face formidable challenges in terms of repression and eliciting elite defection. In sum, excluded ethnic groups face particularly high barriers when it comes to mobilizing large crowds, winning over defections from regime elites, and thwarting state repression. This may be particularly true when the excluded group is small. As a result, these types of ethnic groups are less likely to get a civil resistance campaign off the ground or even to attempt a civil resistance strategy in the first place.

Scholars of nonviolent action might object to the idea that ethnicity presents a barrier to civil resistance by noting that an adherence to nonviolent tactics presents an opportunity for groups to build support from across social divides. For example, Chenoweth and Stephan (2011) specifically argue that a strategic advantage

of civil resistance is that it attracts participants from a broader and more diverse array of social groups. It is likely true that nonviolent tactics more easily facilitate the crossing of social divides than violent ones do. However, eschewing violence may be insufficient when it comes to bridging these cleavages. Ethnic-based grievances that fuel a desire for political change may not be shared by other groups, while leaders' ability to inspire (or coerce) collective action is unlikely to travel beyond members of the ethnic group. Furthermore, McLauchlin (forthcoming) demonstrates that even when excluded groups attempt to transcend ethnic cleavages by framing goals in nonethnic terms, fears about loss of status and even reprisal among privileged groups will make them unlikely to join the campaign. In the case of Syria, concerted efforts by the predominantly Sunni resistance movement failed to produce substantial Alawi participation, especially as the Assad regime strategically stoked sectarian violence in an effort to exacerbate this "loyalty trap."

Civil resistance campaigns may in fact be more diverse in terms of number of groups participating, but due to the constraints described above, I predict that this is most likely to take the form of excluded ethnic groups joining along in campaigns led by politically privileged ethnic groups where ethnic political claims are not present. Civil resistance campaigns initiated by excluded ethnic groups will be rare, as will be privileged groups participating in campaigns where ethnic claims are made.

In sum, I build on the horizontal inequalities literature that predicts that ethnic groups facing political exclusion will be more likely to mobilize towards contentious action. However, opportunity structures that are ill-suited to the strategic logic of civil resistance will reduce the likelihood that excluded ethnic groups turn to nonviolent contention. My logic leads to the following set of hypotheses:

H1: *Politically excluded ethnic groups will be less likely to initiate civil resistance campaigns relative to groups that enjoy high levels of access to state power.*

H2: *An ethnic group's relative demographic size will be positively correlated with its probability of initiating a civil resistance campaign.*

Introducing the Ethnic Groups in Contention (EGC) Dataset

To better understand the relationship between ethnicity and insurgency, civil war researchers have collected data on patterns of ethnic recruitment and claims-making

by armed conflict actors. Examples include the Ethnic Armed Conflict dataset (Wimmer, Cederman, and Min 2009) and the ACD2EPR dataset (Wucherpfennig et al. 2012). Until now, however, no equivalent data existed on ethnicity across nonviolent conflicts. The Nonviolent and Violent Campaign Outcomes 2.0 (NAVCO 2.0) dataset (Chenoweth and Lewis 2013) includes binary measures of movement "diversity" along multiple social dimensions, including ethnicity. Movements are coded as ethnically diverse if they include participants from more than one ethnic group, but no information exists on *which* groups participated. It is therefore difficult to discern whether or not a conflict included in NAVCO 2.0 is characterized by ethnic cleavages. For example, a movement comprised only of members of an excluded minority, such as the Tibetan uprising of 1987, and one occurring within an ethnically homogenous society, such as the "June Struggle" in South Korea the same year, are both labeled as not ethnically diverse. Conversely, a movement comprising multiple excluded groups, such as the First Defiance Campaign in South Africa (1952), and one that includes the participation of multiple groups with access to political power, such as the Philippines People Power campaign (1983), are both coded as diverse despite having very different ethnic dynamics. New data is thus required to better understand the role of ethnicity in nonviolent campaigns and to compare its role across different technologies of contention. This article introduces data that fills this gap, under the name "Ethnic Groups in Contention" dataset. The data consists of an effort to link ethnic groups to conflicts in a manner that is conceptually and operationally similar to the ACD2EPR, providing data on nonviolent as well as violent campaigns.

I use the NAVCO 2.0 dataset as the source of nonviolent and violent campaigns. NAVCO 2.0 collects campaign-year information on campaigns that target the state with maximalist political goals (defined as regime-change, secession, or anti-occupation). To be included in the dataset, campaigns must achieve a baseline threshold of 1,000 observably mobilized participants and last for at least one week.¹ I collected each unique campaign onset from NAVCO, defined by the name and political goal of the opposition movement. This results in 251 unique campaigns.

Next, I collected data on the ethnicity of participants involved at the outset of campaigns. This information comes from multiple sources, including the NAVCO 2.0

¹ For a full description of the inclusion criteria for the violent and nonviolent campaigns included in NAVCO 2.0, see Chenoweth and Lewis (2013).

and ACD2EPR datasets, case narratives from the online appendix to [Chenoweth and Stephan \(2011\)](#), the Swarthmore Global Nonviolent Action Database, and numerous secondary sources. Using this information, I attribute one or more ethnic groups to each NAVCO campaign. Ethnic groups come from the set of groups identified by the EPR dataset as “politically relevant,” meaning that at least one organization claims to represent the group in national politics, or the group experiences discrimination by the state ([Cederman et al. 2010](#), 99).

Similar to datasets that provide information on the role of ethnicity in armed conflicts, I do not apply a fixed participation threshold to link an ethnic group to a campaign. According to [Wucherpfennig et al. \(2012, 95\)](#): “it is difficult to impossible to obtain reliable numbers of recruitment, especially for conflicts that are long past and not well documented.” Instead, I code a movement as including members of an ethnic group when there is sufficient evidence in the secondary literature of significant involvement by members of an ethnic group.

In addition to coding all politically relevant ethnic groups that *participate* in the onset of each campaign, I code exactly one ethnic group as the *initiator* of the campaign. This refers to the ethnic group that constitutes a plurality among the group of original campaign participants. Such a distinction is important for testing my hypotheses, as a group’s calculus in deciding whether to launch a campaign is different from its consideration of whether or not to join efforts led primarily by another group. For example, while the 1988 pro-democracy movement in Myanmar included participants from many of the country’s ethnic groups, I code it as being initiated by the Bamar.

Finally, I also record whether or not the campaign makes an explicit ethnic claim as a political goal. Unlike most studies of ethnic civil war, however, I analyze campaigns in which ethnic claims are present as well as those in which they are absent. The theory presented above predicts that ethnic cleavages may present an obstacle to nonviolent action, even if explicit ethnic claims are not made. My approach allows for an examination of the dynamics of ethnic participation even when ethnic grievances are not an explicitly stated goal of the campaign. A complete codebook is available in the appendix to this article.

Table 1 presents selected summary statistics of the ethnic composition of nonviolent and violent campaigns in the NAVCO 2.0 dataset based on the new EGC data. Consistent with arguments that nonviolent strategies attract more diverse participants, I find that 47 percent of nonviolent campaigns include more than one ethnic group. In contrast, only 25 percent of primarily violent

Table 1. Ethnic group participation in NAVCO and ACD conflicts

	EGC Data		ACD2EPR
	Nonviolent	Violent	Violent
Campaign Onsets	96	121	326
Multiple Groups	47%	25%	12%
Average No. Groups	2.17	1.44	1.19
Ethnic Claim	20%	57%	62%
<i>Participation by Group</i>			
Average Sum Group Size	.71	.41	.30
Sr. Partners and Above.	69%	34%	26%
Junior Partners	17%	11%	14%
Excluded	50%	61%	61%
Irrelevant	16%	13%	7%
<i>Initiation by Group</i>			
Average Initiator Size	.59	.36	
Sr. Partners and Above	65%	31%	
JuniorPartners	4%	8%	
Excluded	21%	52%	
Irrelevant	10%	9%	

campaigns include multiple ethnic groups.² Two additional measures from the new group-specific ethnicity data further corroborate this pattern. The average number of groups participating in a movement is higher for nonviolent campaigns (2.17) than for violent ones (1.44). Additionally, the average cumulative size of groups as a share of the country’s population is higher for nonviolent campaigns (.71) than it is for violent insurgencies (.41).

However, an analysis of the size and power structure of ethnic groups participating in resistance campaigns reveals a more nuanced picture. While nonviolent campaigns are on average more ethnically diverse in terms of number of participating groups, these movements primarily draw participants from privileged ethnic groups. Indeed, 69 percent of nonviolent campaigns included an ethnic group ranked by EPR as a Senior Partner or higher (Senior Partner, Dominant, or Monopoly). Examples include many of the most prominent and frequently studied civil resistance campaigns, such as the

²A similar analysis could be conducted using the ethnic diversity measure in the NAVCO 2.0 dataset alone. That measure codes a greater number of both nonviolent and violent campaigns as “diverse,” 64 percent and 41 percent respectively, but a similar pattern of greater diversity in primarily nonviolent campaigns. The difference is likely a result of NAVCO 2.0 counting the participation of groups not included in the EPR dataset, either because they are deemed not politically relevant or are considered to be part of a single “parent” ethnic group.

People Power Movement in the Philippines, the Iranian Revolution, the anti-Pinochet campaign in Chile, and the Color Revolutions of the early 2000s. Only 50 percent of nonviolent campaigns included a group coded as “excluded” from power (Discriminated, Powerless, or Self-Exclusion). Conversely, violent campaigns are more likely to include excluded groups, with 61 percent of the total experiencing the participation of at least one excluded group and 34 percent including the participation of a high-status group. Junior Partners, which the EPR data describes as enjoying some inclusion in the executive governance of the state but occupying a subordinate position, participate in both nonviolent and violent campaigns at relatively low rates, 17 percent and 11 percent respectively. Hezbollah (Shia) in Lebanon and the campaign for Slovakian independence from Czechoslovakia are examples of this relatively rare occurrence.

The difference in ethnic participation across nonviolent and violent conflicts is even starker when examining the characteristics of groups coded as the “initiator” of a campaign (i.e., those that constituted a plurality of the original set of participants). High-status ethnic groups initiated 65 percent of nonviolent campaigns, while excluded groups initiated only 21 percent. Examples of these cases include campaigns such as the struggle against Apartheid in South Africa, the IRA in Northern Ireland (in 1968), and the First Intifada in Palestine.

In contrast, excluded groups initiated over one-half (52 percent) of violent campaigns, while high status groups initiated less than one-third (31 percent) of violent insurgencies. Groups initiating nonviolent campaigns also tend to be demographic majorities, constituting on average 59 percent of the country’s population. Groups that initiate violent campaigns, on the other hand, tend to be minorities, representing only an average of 39 percent of the total population. The smallest group to initiate a violent campaign is the Mizo of India, comprising only 0.1 percent of the country’s population. The smallest group to initiate a nonviolent campaign is the Tibetans, accounting for 0.4 percent of China’s population. Finally, while 57 percent of violent campaigns involve an ethnic claim, only 20 percent of nonviolent campaigns do so.

The last column in Table 1 presents a comparative analysis of the ethnic composition of violent campaigns included in the ACD dataset based on the ACD2EPR data. The main differences between the campaigns included in the EGC and ACD2EPR datasets are that the ACD includes only violent campaigns, uses a 25 battle-related death criterion, and disaggregates some conflicts into dyads that otherwise represent a single campaign in NAVCO 2.0. The ACD2EPR data therefore include

a much greater number of campaigns, but ethnic participation patterns largely mirror those observed in the EGC data. In fact, multiple groups and privileged groups participate in violent campaigns at lower rates according to the ACD2EPR than they do in the EGC data.

In sum, these summary statistics show that nonviolent and violent campaigns look very different in terms of ethnic make-up. While nonviolent movements are more likely to attract the participation of multiple ethnic groups, they tend to be initiated by the largest, most politically privileged groups. Unsurprisingly, ethnic claims are rarely expressed in nonviolent campaigns. Violent campaigns are more likely to be initiated by smaller and politically excluded groups. And more often than not, they feature ethnic claims.

Testing the Relationship Between Movement Ethnicity and Conflict Strategy

While the campaign-level data presented above reveal important differences in the ethnic compositions of violent and nonviolent campaigns, they cannot fully test the relationship between ethnic group characteristics and the likelihood of initiating nonviolent and violent campaigns. This requires looking at the full set of ethnic groups, including cases that do not mobilize into campaigns with maximalist political goals.

I begin by using EPR’s group-year data. This consists of over 30,000 group-year observations from 1946 to 2006 (truncated by the end of NAVCO 2.0’s coverage in 2006). The EGC data become the basis for coding a series of dependent variables indicating whether a group initiated or participated in the onset of a nonviolent or violent campaign in a given year.

Table 2 presents the rates at which various categories of ethnic groups initiate violent and nonviolent campaigns. Groups with the greatest access to political power (Senior Partners, Dominant, and Monopoly statuses) have initiated nonviolent campaigns at the highest rate, in 0.91 percent of group-years. Junior Partners and Excluded groups initiate nonviolent campaigns at far lower rates, in 0.07 percent and 0.10 percent of group-years, respectively.

Next, I perform a series of regressions to further test the relationship between ethnicity and nonviolent and violent conflict. I use the *initiation* variable as the dependent variable, which takes a positive value if the ethnic group initiated (i.e., made up a plurality of the initial participants) a campaign in that year. Cases in which a group participated either in an onset or in an ongoing campaign initiated by a different group are dropped.

Table 2. Rates of campaign initiation by ethnic group status

EPR Status	Group-Years	Initiated Nonviolent		Initiated Violent	
Sr. Partner and Above	6,705	61	0.91%	37	0.55%
Jr. Partner	5,806	4	0.07%	10	0.17%
Excluded	19,168	20	0.10%	63	0.33%

As in the descriptive statistics above, I collapse the EPR ethnic status variable into three discrete levels to test my theoretical framework: Excluded Groups (Self Exclusion, Powerless, and Discriminated), Junior Partners, and Senior Partners and Above. The last level serves as the reference category. I keep Junior Partners separate as several studies have shown that these groups behave differently than either Excluded or more privileged groups when it comes to participating in civil wars or coup attempts (Cederman et al. 2010; Roessler 2011; Johnson and Thurber, forthcoming). That said, my theory remains agnostic as to how this particular category of ethnic group might behave in civil resistance campaigns. My prediction is simply that Excluded Groups will be less likely to initiate a nonviolent campaign, relative to Senior Partners and Above. I also use EPR’s estimates of ethnic group size to test the hypothesis that smaller groups will be less likely to initiate nonviolent campaigns.

I control for a number of factors that might be correlated with movement strategy and the social structure of a state. First, I use a logged measure of a country’s population, lagged one year, to account for positive correlations between the onset of violent and nonviolent movements and population size (Chenoweth and Lewis 2013; Butcher and Svensson 2016). Next, I include a measure for per capita Gross Domestic Product (GDP) to control for state capacity in terms of overall economic productivity (Fearon and Laitin 2003). GDP is also likely correlated to modernization, which Butcher and Svensson (2016) suggest produces stronger social networks and environments more conducive to nonviolent mobilization. Per capita GDP values are lagged one year and logged.³ I also include a count variable for the number of times an ethnic group has participated in a non-violent and violent campaign in the past. This accounts for path dependencies in group repertoires of contention (Tilly 2008).

³Population and GDP data come from the 2013 update to Gleditsch’s (2002) “Expanded Trade and GDP Data.” The original source for the GDP data is Feenstra, Inlkar, and Timmer’s (2015) “Penn World Tables v. 8.0.”

State-centric approaches to the study of conflict would suggest that highly repressive regimes push aggrieved groups away from nonviolent forms of contention (Goodwin 2001) and may also exclude ethnic minorities (Roessler 2011). To account for regime attributes, I include two indices from the V-DEM project (Coppedge et al. 2017): the Polyarchy measure of degree of electoral democracy, and the Physical Integrity Index as a measure of the regime’s prior use of repression against civilians. Each of these is lagged one year.

All models include cubic polynomials (Carter and Signorino 2010) for the number of years since the end of the last violent campaign and the number of years since the end of the last nonviolent campaign in each country. This controls for the path dependence of contentious repertoires, enduring campaign infrastructures, and other potentially time-dependent factors. I do not report coefficients for these variables in the results tables, but they are available in the online appendix.

I use multinomial logit models to assess the relationship between these covariates and the onset of violent and nonviolent campaigns. While my theoretical framework pertains primarily to the onset of nonviolent campaigns, I follow Cunningham (2013) and Butcher and Svensson (2016) in employing a multinomial model. This helps account for the possibility that that the decision to choose one strategy over another likely influences future use of the non-chosen strategy, often to the point of exclusion. Furthermore, the multinomial model allows me to evaluate the impact of different variables simultaneously on both violent and nonviolent outcomes. This provides a more complete understanding of how various factors affect the broader landscape of contentious politics. It is, however, possible that members of the same ethnic group are involved in both types of campaigns within the same year. This occurs only once in the data, in 1958 in Venezuela. I drop this case in the multinomial models as it makes little sense to include a fourth outcome variable for a single case. However, I include results for ordinary logit models (in which violent and nonviolent outcomes are modeled independently) in the online appendix to show that dropping this case does not significantly alter the results.

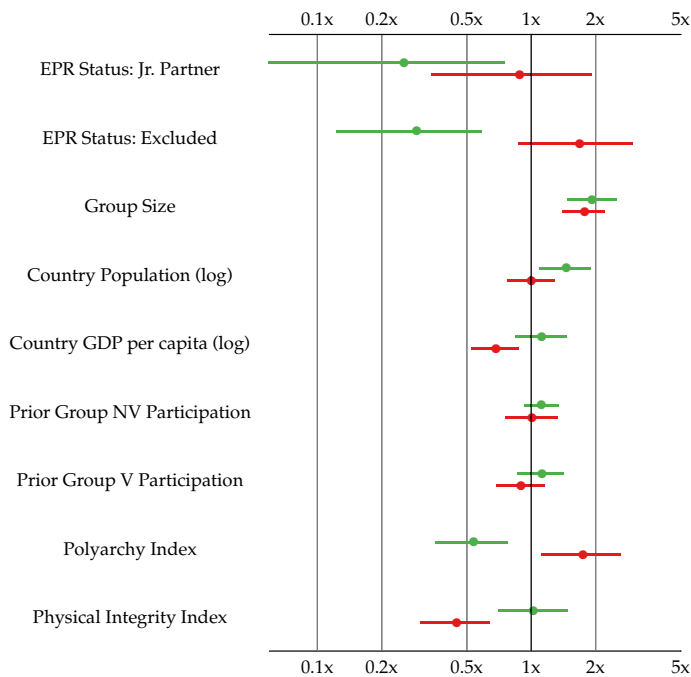


Figure 1. Risk ratios of initiating a nonviolent or violent campaign as covariates are increased from 0 to 1 (EPR status) or from their mean to one standard deviation above the mean. Risk ratios for nonviolent onsets on top, violent onsets below

Results

The analysis shows a strong negative relationship between political exclusion and the likelihood of a group initiating nonviolent campaigns. Figure 1 presents simulated risk ratios from the base model, and Table 3 includes coefficients and standard errors. In terms of odds, excluded groups are a little less than one-third as likely to initiate a nonviolent campaign compared to groups with Senior Partner or higher status. By contrast, the relationship between excluded status and onset of a violent campaign is positive, though this result falls just short of statistical significance.⁴

⁴This is a slight contrast to the results presented in Cederman et al. (2010), which shows a stronger relationship between exclusion and violent conflict. This discrepancy is likely a result of three differences between the two studies: (1) their use of the 25 battle-related death threshold, which produces a greater number of conflicts, particularly those launched by excluded ethnic groups; (2) their restricted examination of those conflicts where ethnic claims are made; and (3) their inclusion of Junior Partners in the reference category, alongside higher status groups. As Model 3 in Table 3 shows, including Junior Partners in the reference cate-

Group size is positively correlated with both nonviolent and violent campaign initiation. Figure 1 shows that when group size increases from the mean to one standard deviation above the mean (from 18 percent to 44 percent of the population), the likelihood of a group initiating a nonviolent campaign nearly doubles.

Figure 2 illustrates the results of Model 1 through a series of expected probability plots. The plots in the top row depict a strong positive correlation between group size and the onset of nonviolent campaigns, ranging from expected probabilities near zero for tiny Excluded groups to as high as 0.031 for Senior Partners and Above that make up nearly all of a state’s population. Importantly, group status has a considerable effect on the initiation of nonviolent campaigns. For even the largest Excluded groups, as shown in the top-right plot, the expected probability of initiating a nonviolent campaign is less than .01. Conversely, the top-left plot shows that Senior Partners and Above need only make up 52 percent of the population to have the same probability of initiating a nonviolent campaign. When comparing the likelihood of initiating nonviolent versus violent campaigns among

gory on its own yields a statistically significant positive relationship between exclusion and violent onsets in this study.

Table 3. Initiating violent and nonviolent campaigns (multinomial logit)

	Base Model		Group-Level Controls		Binary IV	
	1 = Nonviolent 0 = No Contention (1a)	1 = Violent 0 = No Contention (1b)	1 = Nonviolent 0 = No Contention (2a)	1 = Violent 0 = No Contention (2b)	1 = Nonviolent 0 = No Contention (3a)	1 = Violent 0 = No Contention (3b)
EPR Status: Jr. Partner	-1.577** (0.646)	-0.224 (0.436)	-1.543** (0.651)	-0.626 (0.454)		
EPR Status: Excluded	-1.316*** (0.397)	0.471 (0.308)	-1.277*** (0.424)	0.031 (0.326)	-0.790** (0.347)	0.564** (0.252)
Group Size	2.465*** (0.489)	2.169*** (0.419)	2.408*** (0.519)	1.434*** (0.472)	3.195*** (0.419)	2.277*** (0.363)
Country Population (log)	0.192*** (0.070)	-0.003 (0.065)	0.173** (0.080)	-0.021 (0.078)	0.205*** (0.070)	0.001 (0.065)
Country GDP Per Capita (log)	0.092 (0.124)	-0.349*** (0.113)	0.094 (0.137)	-0.272** (0.128)	0.126 (0.122)	-0.344*** (0.113)
Prior Group NV Participation	0.253 (0.223)	-0.005 (0.349)	0.234 (0.232)	-0.115 (0.416)	0.235 (0.222)	-0.005 (0.349)
Prior Group V Participation	0.269 (0.299)	-0.286 (0.316)	0.175 (0.318)	-0.557 (0.379)	0.266 (0.300)	-0.283 (0.316)
VDEM Electoral Democracy Index	-2.448*** (0.748)	2.064** (0.815)	-2.648*** (0.822)	2.636*** (0.919)	-2.573*** (0.748)	2.056** (0.815)
VDEM Physical Integrity Index	0.011 (0.646)	-2.847*** (0.638)	0.017 (0.715)	-3.421*** (0.728)	-0.035 (0.647)	-2.851*** (0.638)
Neighboring Kin in Power						
Downgraded						
Horizontal Inequality						
Constant	-9.515*** (1.307)	-3.024*** (1.133)	-9.065*** (1.423)	-2.824** (1.271)	-10.500*** (1.281)	-3.202*** (1.085)
Observations	30,601		22,810		30,601	
Log Likelihood	-1,087		-924		-1092	
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01 GDP and population lagged 1 year. Cubic polynomials for time not displayed.					

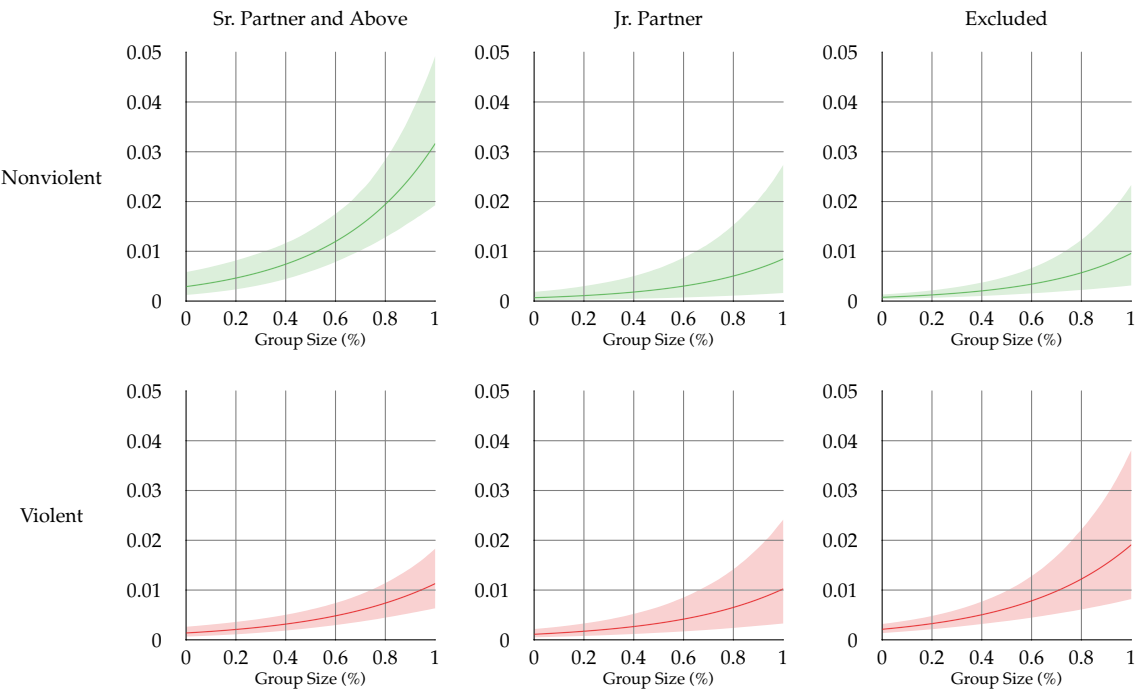


Figure 2. Expected probability of initiating a nonviolent or violent campaign by ethnic group size and status

groups with similar status, the pair of plots in the left-most column of Figure 2 shows that for Senior Partners and Above, the predicted probability of initiating a nonviolent campaign is over twice that of initiating a violent campaign irrespective of group size. Among Excluded groups, the two plots in the rightmost column show the reverse relationship: the predicted probability of violence is over twice that of nonviolence across the range of group sizes. Interestingly, Junior Partners are unlikely to initiate either nonviolent or violent campaigns. Such groups may fear that initiating either type of campaign would jeopardize their already tenuous status.

Figure 1 and Table 3 show that the control variables behave largely as expected. Country population is positively correlated with nonviolent onsets, while GDP is negatively correlated with violent onsets. Counts of prior group participation in violent and nonviolent conflicts show no significant correlation to the likelihood of new violent or nonviolent onsets. The V-Dem Electoral Democracy Index is positively correlated with the initiation of violent campaigns, a result that is consistent with some findings from the literature on terrorism and democracy (Chenoweth 2010). Conversely, the electoral index is negatively correlated with the initiation of non-violent campaigns, consistent with recent work that examines the relationship between regime type, contentious

claims, and the onset of violent and nonviolent conflict (Cunningham et al. 2017). V-Dem’s Physical Integrity Index is negatively correlated with violent onsets, indicating that prior repression decreases the likelihood of violence. In fact, moving from the mean physical integrity score to one standard deviation above the mean decreases the likelihood of a violent campaign by nearly one-fifth. However, there is no statistically significant relationship between physical integrity scores and nonviolent onsets, consistent with previous findings in the civil resistance literature that prior state repression does not have an effect on when and where we see nonviolent campaigns emerge (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011; Chenoweth and Lewis 2013).

Table 3 includes two additional models to assess the robustness of the main findings. Model 2 adds additional group-level covariates available in the EPR project (Vogt et al. 2015). A dichotomous variable measures whether transnational kin occupy a position of power in a neighboring country. Groups with neighboring kin might be more likely to be excluded out of fears of forming a “fifth column,” and may also have enhanced abilities to mount an armed insurgency. Including this variable allows me to evaluate whether excluded ethnic groups’ lower likelihoods of engaging in nonviolent resistance results from greater opportunities for violent rebellion.

I also include a measure of whether the group has been downgraded in status in the past five years, as well as a measure of economic horizontal inequality. These measures help capture conditions that are likely to generate group grievances, but that unlike access to political power should not significantly impact a group's opportunity to mobilize towards nonviolent action. Including these variables tests the validity of relative deprivation arguments, which contend that ethnic grievances incite psycho-social responses that lead groups to violence. The results from Model 2 only report a statistically significant negative correlation between downgraded status and the onset of violence.⁵ The significance and direction of the study's main independent variables remain unchanged in Model 2.

Model 3 collapses the categorical political inclusion variable into a single binary distinction between "included" and "excluded" groups, eliminating Junior Partner as its own level and rolling it into the reference category along with the Senior Partner, Dominant, and Monopoly levels. This slightly weakens the relationship between excluded status and nonviolence, though the coefficient for *Excluded* is still significant at the $p < 0.05$ level. The positive relationship between exclusion and violence also becomes statistically significant in this model, consistent with prior studies on ethnic conflict that include a dichotomous measure of exclusion (Cederman et al. 2010).

Table 4 presents two additional models that include varied operationalizations of the dependent variable. Model 4 includes only regime-change campaigns, dropping NAVCO 2.0 secessionist and anticolonial campaigns. A large number of insurgencies launched by excluded ethnic groups have the objective of securing degrees of territorial autonomy. Arguably, autonomy campaigns may rely on a different strategic logic for which civil resistance may be less well-suited. As such, an examination of only those campaigns that seek the overthrow of a central government provides stronger assurance that any observed relationship between political exclusion and a nonviolent strategy is not simply a function of the nature of the goal being pursued⁶

⁵While the lack of a statistically significant relationship for Horizontal Inequalities and Neighboring Kin in Power differs from prior work on ethnic conflict, it is likely a consequence of the different threshold standards of the NAVCO 2.0 and ACD datasets. The direction of the relationship exhibited in Model 2b is consistent with prior studies.

⁶For a detailed analysis of the use of nonviolence in self-determination disputes, a category that largely overlaps

Finally, Model 5 includes all cases where an ethnic group participated in the onset of a campaign, not simply those where ethnic groups were coded as "initiators." The logic elaborated in my theoretical framework applies primarily to the act of initiating a campaign: small excluded ethnic groups may feel comfortable joining a nonviolent campaign under the umbrella of larger, more privileged groups. However, the theory would have little value if it were easy for such groups to form a coalition with larger, higher status, partners. Furthermore, the definition of initiators as constituting a plurality of first movers could be privileging larger groups in a way that is a function of the operationalization and not the theory. The findings presented in Table 4 indicate that the effects of ethnic group political status and size on civil resistance are both robust to these alternative specifications.

Additional models including regional and decade fixed effects, simple logits, rare events logits, probits, and models with robust standard errors clustered at the group and state levels are presented in the online appendix. The results from these models continue to provide support to my main hypotheses.

Discussion

The findings from both the comparative descriptive analysis of the ethnic composition of campaigns as well as the group-level regressions offer substantial evidence that ethnic structures—both access to political power and demographic size—affect the propensities of groups to initiate campaigns of nonviolent resistance. Political exclusion is consistently negatively correlated with nonviolent onsets in all of the quantitative models: excluded ethnic groups are only one-third as likely as groups with Senior Partner or higher status to initiate a civil resistance campaign. This stands in contrast to violent campaigns, where participation by excluded groups is the norm and where a strong positive relationship between exclusion and violence has been established in the literature (Cederman et al. 2010). Though the relationship between ethnic status and violent insurgency is somewhat weaker in this study compared to previous ones, this is likely a result of the different thresholds for entry used by the NAVCO 2.0 and the ACD datasets and of prior studies' more narrow focus on conflicts where groups make ethnic claims.

It is also interesting to compare the relative impact of group size on nonviolent and violent campaign

with EPR's concept of Self-Exclusion, see Cunningham, Dahl, and Frugé (2017).

Table 4. Alternative dependent variables

	Regime-Change Only		Any Participation	
	<i>1 = Nonviolent</i> <i>0 = No Contention</i> (4a)	<i>1 = Violent</i> <i>0 = No Contention</i> (4b)	<i>1 = Nonviolent</i> <i>0 = No Contention</i> (5a)	<i>1 = Violent</i> <i>0 = No Contention</i> (5b)
EPR Status: Jr. Partner	-1.399** (0.656)	-0.472 (0.551)	-0.407 (0.282)	-0.293 (0.367)
EPR Status: Excluded	-1.743*** (0.459)	0.064 (0.359)	-0.563** (0.239)	0.542** (0.264)
Group Size	2.844*** (0.521)	2.701*** (0.494)	0.920*** (0.344)	1.556*** (0.367)
Country Population (log)	0.193** (0.077)	-0.154 (0.095)	-0.008 (0.046)	-0.080 (0.056)
Country GDP Per Capita (log)	0.010 (0.136)	-0.478*** (0.154)	-0.115 (0.081)	-0.451*** (0.098)
Prior Group NV Participation	0.384* (0.232)	0.146 (0.436)	0.619*** (0.150)	-0.004 (0.329)
Prior Group V Participation	-0.019 (0.323)	-0.457 (0.393)	0.333* (0.202)	-0.066 (0.261)
Constant	-9.133*** (1.416)	-1.615 (1.518)	-5.061*** (0.828)	-1.284 (0.963)
Observations	30,551		30,739	
Log Likelihood	-776		-1854	
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01 GDP and population lagged 1 year. Cubic polynomials for time not displayed.				

onsets. In four out of five models presented, the group size coefficient for the outcome of a nonviolent campaign is larger than that for a violent campaign. However, a test for difference between coefficients (Paternoster et al. 1998) shows that only the group size coefficients in Model 3 are statistically distinguishable from each other, and even then, only at the $p < 0.1$ level. Thus, while larger group size clearly increases the likelihood of both nonviolent and violent campaigns, there is insufficient evidence to conclude that it affects the likelihood of civil resistance campaigns to a greater degree than it does violent campaigns.

The findings also show that alternative explanations are inadequate in explaining the relationship between exclusion and the onset of nonviolent campaigns. The diversity advantage of nonviolent resistance does not seem to apply as strongly for excluded groups. In fact, excluded groups participated more frequently in violent, as opposed to nonviolent, campaigns. Moreover, when excluded groups do participate in nonviolent campaigns, they are rarely the initiating group (21 percent of cases) and also rarely make ethnic claims (20 percent of cases).

Furthermore, the negative relationship between political exclusion and nonviolent campaigns holds across different specifications of the dependent variable, for example when it is expanded to include all participating ethnic groups, not just initiators. Excluded groups are on average less likely to participate in nonviolent campaigns, and when they do, it is often under the umbrella of more privileged groups espousing political goals not specific to ethnicity.

The empirical analysis also finds substantial support for the role of state-level structures in influencing the choices available to ethnic groups. Regime type and repressive behavior appear to shape the opportunities available to movements, though there is no observed relationship between a regime's prior repressive behavior and the likelihood of an ethnic group initiating a nonviolent campaign. This is consistent with findings from the extant literature. Additionally, group-level measures of grievance and opportunity performed more poorly in Model 2, with only downgraded status having a statistically significant effect on the likelihood of ethnic groups initiating a violent campaign.

More importantly, measures of political status and group size remain significantly correlated to the initiation of nonviolent campaigns even when group-level controls are included in the analysis. This increases confidence that the observed relationships are in fact the result of constraints resulting from political exclusion and small group size, rather than the product of statewide patterns of repression or frustration/aggression urges sparked by group grievances.

Some limitations of this study are important to note. Because the NAVCO 2.0 data only includes campaigns that reach a 1,000 participant threshold, we do not know whether the relationships identified in this study hold at lower levels of contention. Indeed, disaggregated data on smaller social disruptions might highlight different patterns. For example, the current data do not allow us to disaggregate between movements that reject civil resistance *a priori* versus those that attempt civil resistance but fail to achieve participation thresholds that include them in NAVCO 2.0. In all likelihood, there are examples of both types of cases, and both pathways are consistent with the logic put forth in this article: structural constraints prevent certain ethnic groups from getting a civil resistance campaign off the ground.

Finally, it is possible that a psychological frustration-aggression response (Davies 1962; Gurr 1970) to inter-group inequalities could also explain the reduced likelihood of nonviolent contention from excluded groups. In this scenario, groups turn to arms as a violent emotional response to injustice. Rational and psychological mechanisms could work in tandem, and the theory presented in this article does not exclude the possibility that rational deliberations could be colored by psychological biases. But the robustness of the main quantitative findings even when group-level measures of grievance were included in Model 2 combined with the numerous qualitative accounts of social movements engaging in organized strategic deliberations described earlier provides evidence in support of my opportunity-based theoretical framework.

Conclusion

This article has sought to apply insights from scholarship on ethnic conflicts to the study of an alternative mode of political contention: nonviolent civil resistance. In so doing, it has challenged a central tenet of civil resistance scholarship that agency matters more than structure in shaping the course of nonviolent campaigns. The very logic through which nonviolence has proven effective for so many campaigns around the globe in fact poses particular challenges for ethnic groups that are politically excluded, especially when those ethnic groups are

small in size. Consequently, we see relatively few civil resistance campaigns launched by such groups, especially when compared to violent campaigns.

The argument and findings presented in this study are agnostic as to whether violence or nonviolence is more effective in helping marginalized ethnic groups achieve their goals. The historical track record for violent campaigns revealed in Chenoweth and Stephan (2011) suggests that turning to arms is rarely an effective strategy. I argue simply that ethnic groups and their movements face greater obstacles to nonviolent mobilization relative to those that recruit from politically privileged ethnic groups. They are thus relatively less likely to be able to (or to anticipate being able to) initiate a civil resistance campaign.

Admittedly, the specific mechanisms through which excluded ethnic groups make strategic decisions cannot be ascertained through the statistical methods used in this study. In particular, the study has not answered the following questions: To what degree are movements consciously and rationally deliberating strategic alternatives? To what degree are they being influenced by psychological or emotional dynamics? Are movements attempting tactics more or less at random, with some gaining traction and others failing before they ever take off? Future qualitative research may be able to shed greater light on these processes and pathways.

This study also provides potential new insights for the study of violent conflict. Scholarship on civil war has generally considered aggrieved groups, especially ethnic groups, as having but two choices: violent rebellion or accepting the political status quo. As the empirical and scholarly records show, however, a third option exists. Research on civil wars therefore needs to ask not just why and how certain groups seek to overthrow a regime, but why they rule out nonviolent strategies as a possible means of achieving political ends. My argument that the strategic logic of civil resistance poses unique challenges to excluded ethnic groups may help explain why civil wars play out along ethnic cleavages so much more frequently than along any other type of politically salient division.

The findings also have important implications for policymakers and practitioners. They may be of particular interest to those involved in promoting nonviolent methods of activism and/or deterring the use of violence. This study highlights a particular type of social movement that may be more skeptical of nonviolent action and thus also more likely embrace the alternative of violent insurgency. Rather than simply asserting that nonviolence is effective in all conditions, policymakers and practitioners may wish to directly confront the

particular challenges excluded ethnic groups face when attempting to utilize this strategy.

Supplementary Information

Supplementary information is available at the *Journal of Global Security Studies* data archive.

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